



EXIT! POLLS

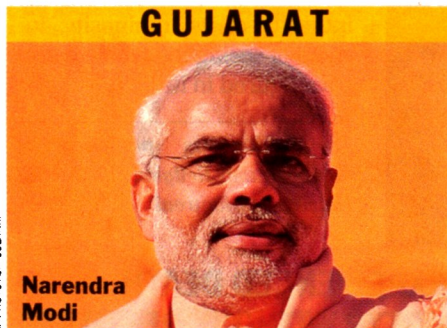
The problem with exit polls lies in the complexity of the populace and the inability of pollsters to create a robust model to analyse the responses of the voters

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

Pollsters once billed exit polls as the political cousin of quantum physics. They claimed it could measure the impact of political energy over the masses by collecting the voices of voters as they poured out of the booths and convert it into seats. That now seems a distant era and a dying boast. Their worst hour was E 2004 when some predicted an NDA majority. You would have thought that since then the pollsters would have re-examined the coordinates and the calculus to get the prediction matrix right. You would assume that they would use every opportunity and every election to make their models more robust to survive the vicious turbulence of politics. Yes, they do seem to get the trend but with every passing exit poll their predictions resemble more like the report of the meteorological department or worse, whereas their "science" requires them to nail a number. Nothing emphasises this better than the distance between the exit poll predictions and the actual results in Gujarat. The Gujarat elections afforded the pollsters the showpiece, the perfect stage—with a clear bi-polar contest on hand—to execute their craft. Sadly even the best attempt was widely off the mark. Even Star News, which was closest to the final verdict, predicted 14 seats less in a house of 182. Worse, thanks to the high decibel campaign, most polls found an as yet unstated logic to give Congress between 70 and 95 seats,

much more respectable than its eventual score of 59. Interestingly, Star News at the end of the first phase, had given BJP 115 seats while NDTV discovered the psephological version of having the cake and eating it too. Its projection for Congress ranged from 70 seats to 95 seats—a margin of 25 seats in a house of 182. It would have been right even if the Congress had won.

Intuitively, it would seem that in Gujarat the interpretation of the exit poll data suffered from the hangover of the 2004 Lok Sabha polls where the Congress was leading in over 90 assembly seats because nothing else explains the high numbers for the Congress. It couldn't be that people misled pollsters out of fear. Perhaps it wasn't that simple but we don't know what it was. Just as we don't know why the pollsters failed to map Mayawati's magic. But what went wrong in Uttar Pradesh? The pollsters missed the outcome by the proverbial mile. Even the best projection placed the winner BSP at 152-168. None of the pollsters could even catch a glint of the magic of Maya that swept her in with an absolute majority. Two factors could have caused this: the failure to recognise the higher turnout among backward sections, thanks to the Election Commission and the inability to find ways to capture the silent mind of the oppressed voter championed by BSP. Also, quite often, the model isn't able to gauge the value of alliances—like the strength of the JD(U)-led alliance in Bihar which ousted the



	BJP	CONG+NCP	Others
STAR NEWS	103	76	3
NDTV	90-110	70-95	3-5
CNN-IBN	92-100	77-85	3-7
ACTUAL SEATS	117	62	3

They didn't catch the sweep and over-estimated the ability of the Congress. NDTV was unique with a 70-95 range for Congress which meant it would have been right even if the BJP had lost.

Elections were held in December 2007; Congress won 59 seats and NCP 3